

PROTECT YOUR EARS.

Keep the music. For the crowd in the room, and for the player standing next to the source.

85 dBA

NIOSH'S RECOMMENDED LIMIT FOR AN 8-HOUR DAY. LIVE MUSIC OFTEN RUNS LOUDER THAN THAT — ON STAGE AND IN THE ROOM. NEAR 100 dBA, THAT DAY'S DOSE IS ABOUT 15 MINUTES.

01 WHY A SET IS LOUD ENOUGH TO MATTER

AN 8-HOUR AVERAGE

NIOSH's recommended limit is 85 dBA over eight hours. Every extra 3 dB cuts that time in half. OSHA's legal 8-hour cap is 90 dBA; a hearing program starts at 85. Those rules were written for workplaces. The dose math is the same in a club.

THE PLAYER IS CLOSER

A wedge, a kit, or a small rehearsal room puts the source at the ear. NIOSH has found stage and rehearsal levels that pass 85 dBA and can pass 100 dBA. The crowd is in the same room. The musician is nearer the speaker.

A SET OUTLASTS THE WINDOW

About an hour around 94 dBA is a full day on the NIOSH scale. At about 100 dBA, that allowance is roughly 15 minutes. A bar, a festival, or a rehearsal often runs longer than that window. Ringing or a muffled feeling afterward means the night was loud enough to count.

02 HI-FI FILTERS VS. FOAM

HI-FI

MUSIC YOU WANT TO HEAR

A musician or high-fidelity filter lowers the level and keeps the balance closer to the mix. Vocals and pitch stay usable. The usual pick for a show, a rehearsal, or a demo you came to hear.

WHEN

You want the music, just quieter. Audience and most playing.

FOAM

WHEN QUIET MATTERS MORE

Higher labeled reduction, and it dulls the highs first. The mix goes muddy. Fine when the goal is simply less sound — not the plug you try to tune or sing through.

WHEN

Maximum quiet beats tone. A painful wedge, or a room that is simply too loud.

STAGE

CLOSER THAN THE CROWD

The back of the room can often live with a moderate flat filter. At the wedge, the kit, or in a garage-sized rehearsal, start with a stronger filter you can still play through.

WHEN

You are next to the source. Foam only if the filter is not enough.

03 WHERE THIS CARD BELONGS

1 CONCERTS AND FESTIVALS

The room stays loud for the whole set. A flat filter keeps it musical.

3 REHEARSAL ROOMS AND THE STAGE

Small rooms and monitors. Stronger filter, still one you can play through.

2 LOUD BARS AND CLUBS

A house system plus a packed room adds up over a night, not one song.

4 MUSIC-STORE DEMO ROOMS

A loud amp in a small room is still a dose. Same idea as rehearsal.

